

EAST ASIAN WEAPONS AND ARMOUR

Lamellar (scaled) armour – made from small rectangular iron, leather, or bronze plates laced together – originated in the classical world, but was perfected by the Japanese: from the 11th century onwards, nobility wore the *o-yoroi* (armour), specifically designed for mounted archers. By the 14th century, the design of Japanese swords reached its peak; a superior *tachi* or curved blade, worthy of an expensive mount (hilt and scabbard), was a symbol of high status, and samurai wore their swords not only on the battlefield but also when in civilian dress. In China, lamellar armour was replaced by armour made from plates riveted to a fabric backing, similar to the European brigandine. Following the Mongol invasion of China in the 13th century, curved swords influenced by the steppe sabre became more widely used alongside the classic straight-edged *jian*, and by the middle of the Ming dynasty (1368–1644), many swords had also been imported from Japan into China. It was during this period that Chinese gunpowder weapons were first used in battle.

► O-YOROI

Date c.1340

Origin Japan

Material Iron, copper gilt, rawhide, silk, leather, lacquer

The cuirass of the *o-yoroi* (armour) was made of two parts, with a separate iron plate tied to the body on the right-hand side. The standing flanges on the shoulder straps prevented the shoulder guards from hurting the neck when a soldier raised his arms to draw his bow.

◄ RED-LACED O-YOROI

Date c.1360

Origin Japan

Material Iron, copper gilt, rawhide, silk, leather, lacquer

This spectacular *o-yoroi* was made as a votive offering for the Kasuga Shrine in Nara. All the major pieces are decorated with copper gilt ornaments depicting tigers in bamboo. Large *kuwagata* (stylized deer horn) crests adorn the peak.

